MAYA TALIAFERRO

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MayaTaliaferro98@gmail.com

EDUCATION

2023 - Present **Ph.D. Psychology**
New York University - New York, New York
Advisor: Dr. Esti Blanco-Elorrieta

2017 - 2021 **B.A. Neuroscience** *GPA*: 3.75 *Latin Honors:* Magna Cum Laude
Hamilton College – Clinton, New York

OTHER EDUCATION & COURSES

2026 **Genetics and Neurobiology of Language –** Cold Spring Harbor Laboratories
Intensive course examining the bases and origins of speech and language, through talks, interactive sessions, keynotes and debates, involving leading experts from a range of disciplines.

2026 **Pedagogy in Theory and Practice –** New York University
Course in pedagogical theory, syllabus and assessment design, and teaching philosophy development

2021 **Semester Abroad**
Doshisha University – Kyoto, Japan

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Multilingualism, Communication, Language Processing & Acquisition, Behavioral & Neural Correlates

FELLOWSHIPS & GRANTS

2025 - 2028 **National Defense Science and Engineering Graduate Fellowship** ($144,500)
2023 - 2028 **NYU GSAS Dean's Doctoral Fellowship** ($51,200)
2023 - 2025 **NYU MacCracken Fellowship** ($32,880)
2017 - 2021 **Ellis Foundation Scholarship** ($4,000)

AWARDS & HONORS

2025 **NYU Dean's Conference Award** Period 3 ($500)
2025 **Travel Award** Cognitive Science Society ($1000)
2024 **Travel Award** Society for Neurobiology of Language ($550)
2022 **MIT School of Science Quality of Life Grant** ($3000)
2021 **Dr. Phillip I. Bowman Scholarship Prize (**$3000**)**
2021 **Sigma Xi** International Scientific Research Honor Society
2021 **Phi Sigma Iota** International Foreign Language Honor Society
2020 **Benjamin A. Gilman International Scholarship** ($5000)
2019 **Psi Chi** National Honors Society in Psychology

JOURNAL PUBLICATIONS

Taliaferro, M., & Schulz, L. (2026). Brown bear, brown bear, what do you see? Speakers use more redundant color adjectives when speaking to children than adults. *Open Mind: Discoveries in Cognitive Science.*

Malik-Moraleda, S., **Taliaferro, M.,** Shannon, S., Jhinkan, N., Swords, S., Frommer, P., Peterson, D., Okrand, M., Sims, J., Cardwell, R., Freeman, C., Fedorenko, E. (2025). Constructed languages are processed by the same brain mechanisms as natural languages. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences.*

Bridgers, S., Qian P., Parece, K., **Taliaferro, M.,** Schulz, L., Ullman, T. (2025). Loopholes: A window into value alignment and the communication of meaning. *Cognition*

Malik-Moraleda, S., Jouravlev, O., **Taliaferro**, **M.,** Mineroff, Z., Cucu, T., Mahowald, K., Blank, I., Fedorenko, E. (2024). Functional characterization of the language network of polyglots and hyperpolyglots with precision fMRI. *Cerebral Cortex*

Qian, P., Bridgers, S., **Taliaferro, M**., Parece, K., Ullman, T. (2024). Ambivalence by design: A computational account of loopholes. *Cognition*

Tuckute, G., Sathe, A., Srikant, S., **Taliaferro, M.,** Wang, M., Schrimpf, M., Kay, K., Fedorenko, E. (2023). Driving and suppressing the human language network using large language models. *Nature Human Behavior*

PEER-REVIEWED PROCEEDINGS PUBLICATIONS

Taliaferro, M., Dirani, J., & Blanco-Elorrieta, E. **(**2026). "Recurrent Dynamics Give Rise to Individualized Category Representations" *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society* (Vol. 48).

Taliaferro, M.*, Imel, N.*, Zaslavsky, & Blanco-Elorrieta, E. **(**2025). Bilinguals exhibit semantic convergence while maintaining near-optimal efficiency. *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society* (Vol. 47).

Singh, A.*, **Taliaferro, M.***, Lindsay, G., & Blanco-Elorrieta, E. **(**2025). Blending Boundaries: A Computational Approach to How Bilinguals Reconcile Cross-Linguistic Categorization. *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society* (Vol. 47).

Bejjanki, V*., Gaillard, E., **Taliaferro, M.,** & Taylor, J.* (2025). Influence of Task Complexity on Visuomotor Adaptation. *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society* (Vol. 47).

Taliaferro, M., & Schulz, L. (2024). Brown bear, brown bear, what do you see? Speakers use more redundant color adjectives when speaking to children than adults. *Proceedings of Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society* (Vol. 46).

PRESENTATIONS

Taliaferro, M., Dirani, J., & Blanco-Elorrieta, E. **(**2026). "Recurrent Dynamics Give Rise to Individualized Category Representations" Poster Presentation. *Cognitive Science Society Conference 2026,* Rio de Janeiro, Brazil.

Taliaferro, M., Dirani, J., & Blanco-Elorrieta, E. **(**2025). "Neural Evidence for Shared Conceptual Representations in Bilinguals." Poster Presentation. *Society for Neurobiology of Language 2025,* Washington DC, USA.

Singh, A.*, **Taliaferro, M.***, Lindsay, G., & Blanco-Elorrieta, E. **(**2025). "Blending Boundaries: A Computational Approach to How Bilinguals Reconcile Cross-Linguistic Categorization." Slides Presentation. *Cognitive Science Society Conference 2025,* San Francisco, USA.

Taliaferro, M.*, Imel, N.*, Zaslavsky, N., & Blanco-Elorrieta, E. **(**2025). "Bilinguals exhibit semantic convergence while maintaining near-optimal efficiency." Poster Presentation. *Cognitive Science Society Conference 2025,* San Francisco, USA.

Taliaferro, M., & Blanco-Elorrieta, E. (2024). "Evidence for Language-Shaped Conceptual Representations: Bilinguals Converge on Representations Interposed Between Monolinguals." Poster Presentation. *Society for Neurobiology of Language 2024,* Brisbane, Australia.

Taliaferro, M., & Schulz, L. (2024). "Brown bear, brown bear, what do you see? Speakers use more redundant color adjectives when speaking to children than adults." Slides Presentation. *Cognitive Science Society Conference 2024,* Rotterdam, Netherlands.

Malik-Moraleda, S., **Taliaferro, M.,** Shannon, S., Jhinkan, N., Swords, S., Frommer, P., Peterson, D., Okrand, M., Sims, J., Cardwell, R., Freeman, C., Fedorenko, E. (2023). Slides Presentation. "Constructed languages are processed by the same brain mechanisms as natural languages" *MIT Research Scholars Showcase,* Cambridge, MA

INVITED TALKS

3. *Research Talk. "The Psychology of Categories: How do Minds Represent?"* Columbia University, USA (October 2026)
2. *Research Talk & Panelist. Annual Alumni Event* Hamilton College, USA (October 2025)
1. *Panelist. "The Bilingual Brain: Unlocking Nature's Super Power"* New York, USA (October 2025)

TEACHING & MENTORSHIP

2026 **Guest Lecturer (*PSYCH29 - Fall*)** – New York University
2026 **Teaching Assistant (*PSYCH29 - Fall*)** – New York University
Lead recitations, graded assignments and proctored exams
2026 **Grader (*PSYCH29 - Summer session*)** – New York University
2026 **Teaching Assistant (*PSYCH29 - Spring*)** – New York University
Lead recitations, graded assignments and proctored exams
2025-2026 **Afterschool STEM Mentoring Program (ASMP) Instructor**

New York Academy of Sciences – New York, NY

2025- **Application Support Group Mentor for NYU Psychology Department** New York, NY
Helped PhD applicants through free general application review, 1-on-1 mentorship, and personalized insight into the NYU and other US-based programs

2023 **Instructor ("*Curve fitting in Python")***
MIT Quantitative Methods Workshop – Cambridge, MA

2022 **MIT Summer Research Program Mentor** Cambridge, MA
Mentored 2 undergraduate students in research conducted over the summer at MIT

2018-2021 **Research Tutor**
Hamilton College Library and IT Services – Clinton, NY

2019-2021 **Ellis Scholar Student Mentor**
Aid underrepresented students in the transition from high school to college

2021 **Japanese Tutor**
Hamilton College Language Center – Clinton, NY

2021 **Japanese Grader *(JAPN 101 & 200)***
Hamilton College Asian Studies Department – Clinton, NY

2020 **Cognitive Science Teaching Assistant *(PSYCH 202)***
Hamilton College Psychology Department – Clinton, NY

SERVICE & OUTREACH

2026 **Reviewer** for Communications Biology

2026 **Reviewer** for Cognitive Science Society (CogSci)

2025-2026 **Student Representative for NYU Cognition and Perception Program** New York, NY
Represented student perspectives by attending C&P and Psychology faculty meetings, maintaining communication with students, and assisting in organizing the annual C&P student–faculty meeting

2025 **Ad hoc reviewer** for Cognitive Science Society (CogSci)

2024-2025 **Social Chair for NYU Cognition and Perception Program** New York, NY
Organized and led program-wide social activities to strengthen community within C&P PhD program

2023-2026 **Judge for NYU Masters Research Conference**

2017-2021 **Hamilton Autism Advocates for NeuroDiversity – *Vice President*** Clinton, NY
Coordinated directly with Kelbermann Center to plan and initiate fun activities for children with autism spectrum disorder to encourage social skill development and promote awareness for ASD in local community

2018-2020 **Hamilton Association for Volunteering, Outreach, and Charity** Clinton, NY
Recruited volunteers and organized trips to senior living facility 4 times a semester

COMPUTER SKILLS

Proficient in MATLAB (PsychToolbox), R, Python, JavaScript (jsPsych), Microsoft (Excel, Word, PowerPoint), Qualtrics
Working knowledge in Blender, Adobe AfterEffects, Adobe Photoshop, Adobe Illustrator

LANGUAGES

English: Native Language
Japanese: Intermediate Listener, Intermediate Speaker, Intermediate Reading and Writing